Q+A

Arabian Nights

Neha Dhupia *is excited about her international debut this year with Egyptian director Ali El Arabi's* Blue 52

Q. Tell us about your international debut?

I play the protagonist Ashish's mother in *Blue 52*. The entire experience has been amazing because of the mix of so many different cultures. The different milieus gave me a chance to explore a challenging character who had great emotional resonance. I am fortunate to have a director like Ali for my international debut.

Q. Is this a move away from Bollywood?

I haven't moved away from Bollywood at all. I have a romcom, *Mere Mehboob Mere Sanam*, with Vicky Kaushal and Triptii Dimri coming up soon. It's just that I have a larger canvas now that includes many other projects besides Bollywood. These include reality shows, other TV shows and a talk show. I have a show on mental health lined up as well.

Q. What kind of roles do you want to do?

I want to steer away from conventional roles and do more than the singing and dancing, glamourous heroine roles... like out-of-the-box unpredictable stuff that will make the audience sit up and take notice. I like to break the mould for myself and *Blue 52* has given me a chance to do precisely that.

Q. How important is social media for a celebrity and how do you react to trolling?

Social media sometimes plays a decisive role in your career. For instance, when you are one of the final two shortlisted for a role, your casting could be based on your social media standing.... As for trolling, the first time, it hits you hard. The second time, it does not hit you so hard. By the third time, you stop thinking about it.

–with **Shashi Sunny**

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